

Recontextualising Character Progression

A Social Semiotic Analysis of Gacha Game Interface Interactivity

Haoning Li

PhD candidate in Applied Linguistics, School of the Arts
Queen Mary University of London
haoning.li@qmul.ac.uk

Genshin Impact, and what “gacha” means



Commercial and cultural impact

mobile revenue in its first year, and over US\$3 bn within about 18 months.

- Apple & Google Play Game of the Year 2020
- The Game Awards 2021: Best Mobile Game

“Gacha”

From Japanese *gachapon* (gashapon) capsule-toy vending machines.

A special **opaque selling** approach: the seller sells *pulls*, and each paid pull gives a fixed probability of winning a reward.

Genshin Impact uses a banner-based, multi-item gacha that sells characters.

Definition: Chen & Fang (2023). Awards and revenue: Apple, Google, The Game Awards, Sensor Tower.

So what kind of game is this?

JRPG

Japanese role-playing game

ARPG

Action role-playing game

MMORPG

Massively multiplayer online RPG

Open-world game

Gacha game

Gambling-like

Otaku game

Fantasy game

Sci-fi



From narrative to character

Contemporary media is increasingly organised around characters, not single narratives.

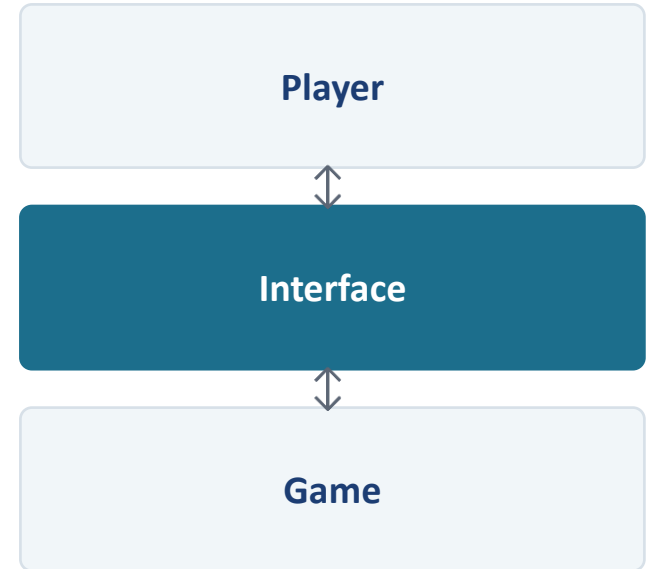


The modern media environment is character-centric; my interest is the micro, semiotic level inside the interface.

Azuma (2009); Steinberg (2012); Blom (2023).

Why the interface?

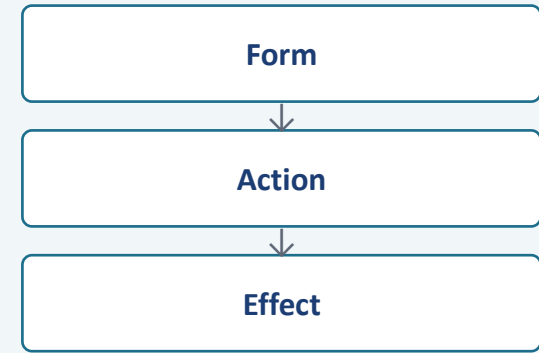
- The interface is the player's layer of mediation with the game: a process, an active threshold mediating between two states (Galloway, 2012).
- In games, the gameworld itself works as an interface (Jørgensen, 2013).
- For multimodal research, interfaces are an established entry point, from web pages and social media to game screens (Bateman et al., 2017).
- Interactive interfaces are among the fastest-growing communicative forms, and they remain under-theorised.



Interactivity as (part of) character-centric discourse

- Interactivity is a meaning-making dimension multimodal studies have long wanted to address.
- This study also touches it, offering one fresh way to read interactivity, in service of the present focus.
- Character-centric discourse is not simply ‘valuing characters’. It arises under the media-mix logic (Blom, 2023) and the gacha logic of selling characters, and is the micro, linguistic manifestation of a concept from game and cultural studies.

Adami (2015): the interactive sign



I adopt this lens, adapting ‘effect’ to ludic states such as configuration and ownership, for the present case.

Adami (2015); Blom (2023); Poulsen (2022).

Research questions

Main

How do gacha game interfaces recontextualise an ergodic character gameplay practice as a character-centric discourse, through multimodal and interactive design?

RQ1

What semiotic resources and compositional arrangements foreground characters as the organising principle of the character-centric interface?

RQ2

How does the interface's interactivity re-represent the ergodic character gameplay practice as a character-centric discourse, in light of the media-mix logic and gacha mechanic of the game?

From 'character progression' to the ergodic character gameplay practice

In the abstract I called this character progression. I now frame it more precisely.

Gameplay is *ergodic*: traversing it takes nontrivial, configurative effort (Aarseth, 1997). The practice (van Leeuwen, 2008) is how players engage characters through the interface.

Acquisition
textonic

Display
presentational

Cultivation
configurative

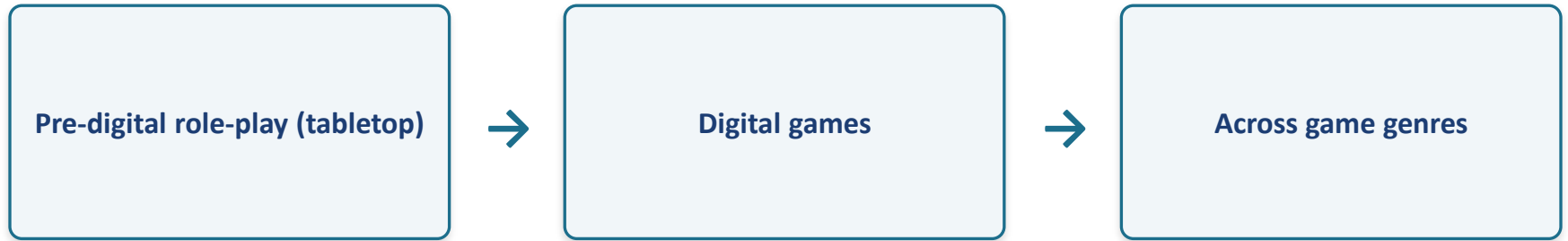
Deployment
explorative + configurative

Four constitutive activities, non-sequential.

Aarseth (1997); van Leeuwen (2008).

Recontextualisation

As a social practice moves into a new context it is transformed, through additions, deletions, rearrangements and substitutions (van Leeuwen, 2008). Resemiotisation names the change of modal and material form (Iedema, 2003; Poulsen, 2022).



The same ergodic character gameplay practice, recontextualised into different forms.

van Leeuwen (2008); Iedema (2003); Poulsen (2022).

Elden Ring vs Genshin Impact

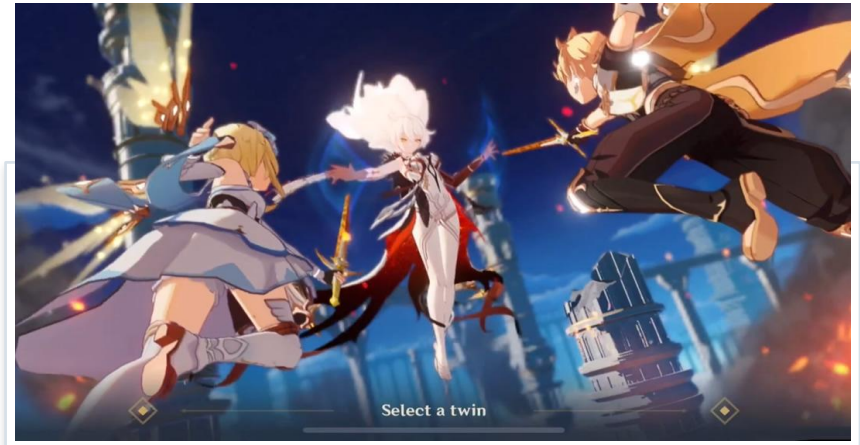
A baseline for comparison, not a source.

Both games are highly prominent. Elden Ring sits at the non-character-centric extreme: the Tarnished is unnamed, one of a nameless multitude. The contrast makes recontextualisation visible. The two games manifest the practice in different ways, and comparing them brings out that difference.

Acquisition



Elden Ring: choose a class



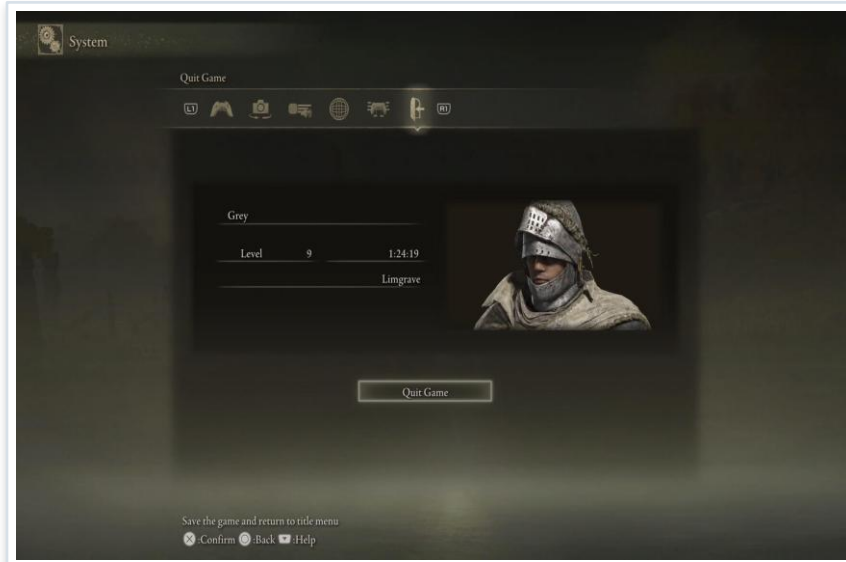
Genshin: choose a twin



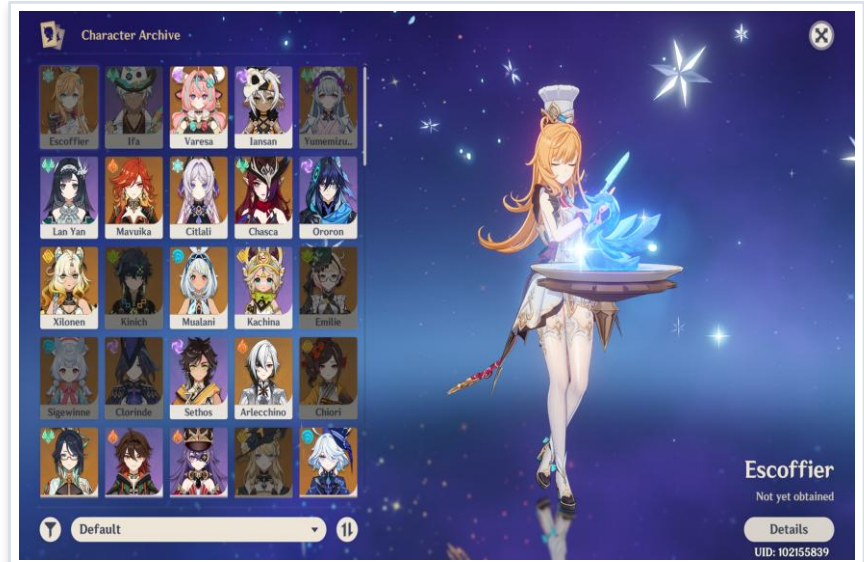
Genshin: Wish banner (gacha)

Acquisition adds characters to the roster (textonic). Gacha foregrounds the character as a collectible, sold through the banner.

Display



Elden Ring: portrait on the system screen



Genshin: Character Archive

Display is peripheral in the baseline; it becomes a dedicated showcase that foregrounds and collects characters.

Cultivation



Elden Ring: status and equipment



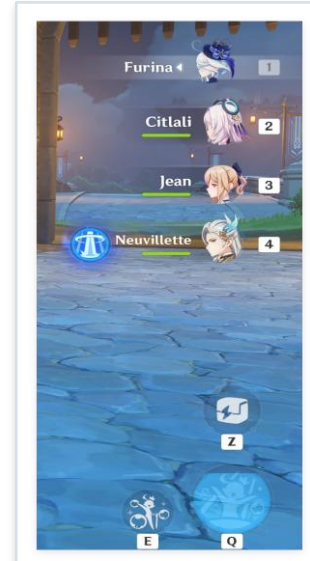
Genshin: building a character (animated)

Configurative work (levelling, artefacts, talents), read through Adami's form, action, effect: an action on a form changes the character's state and configuration.

Deployment



Elden Ring: world and menu



Genshin: party HUD

Explorative and configurative use in the live world. The HUD foregrounds a party of named characters; the baseline stays character-anonymous.

Scope

- Genshin Impact and gacha games do not own these features. Such designs circulate widely as craft conventions across the industry.
- The point is concentration: gacha games gather enough of these features together, around characters, to make the case representative.

An ongoing project

- This is an ongoing PhD project.
- A static, compositional tier of the analysis (the interface canvas; Bateman et al., 2017) sits alongside this interactive account and can be discussed further.
- Future work: quantitative study, and generalisation across other interactive genres and platforms. The analytical approach is built to travel.

References

Aarseth, E. J. (1997). *Cybertext: Perspectives on ergodic literature*. Johns Hopkins University Press.

Adami, E. (2015). What's in a click? A social semiotic framework for the multimodal analysis of website interactivity. *Visual Communication*, 14(2), 133–153.

Azuma, H. (2009). *Otaku: Japan's database animals*. University of Minnesota Press.

Bateman, J., Wildfeuer, J., & Hiippala, T. (2017). *Multimodality: Foundations, research and analysis*. De Gruyter.

Blom, J. (2023). The Genshin Impact media mix: Free-to-play monetisation from East Asia. *Mechademia*, 16(1), 144–166.

Chen, C., & Fang, Z. (2023). Gacha game analysis and design. *Proceedings of the ACM on Measurement and Analysis of Computing Systems*, 7(1).

Galloway, A. R. (2012). *The interface effect*. Polity.

Iedema, R. (2003). Multimodality, resemiotisation. *Visual Communication*, 2(1), 29–57.

Jørgensen, K. (2013). *Gameworld interfaces*. MIT Press.

Kress, G., & van Leeuwen, T. (2021). *Reading images: The grammar of visual design* (3rd ed.). Routledge.

Poulsen, S. V. (2022). The same but different. *Discourse & Communication*, 16(2), 249–268.

Steinberg, M. (2012). *Anime's media mix*. University of Minnesota Press.

van Leeuwen, T. (2008). *Discourse and practice*. Oxford University Press.

Thank you

Haoning Li · haoning.li@qmul.ac.uk

